



## **Assignment #3 - Final Individual Project**

**“Go Beyond Range: Repositioning the Toyota RAV4 PHEV for Emotional Relevance in the Electrified SUV Era”**

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## Executive Summary

The 2025 Toyota RAV4 PHEV drives into a market formed by more than just the rise of electrification — but by a feeling of anticipation. Toyota keeps a sane and reasonable stake in rational equity but the brand has a symbolic impression of needing to make hybrid somewhat more personal, aspirational and culturally resonant. Throughout the campaign there's also a shift in RAV4 being seen as just a merely incrementally functionalist upgrade and more as a lifestyle enabler. Our design intuition reveals a new generation of SUV customer seeking empowered freedom: to live sustainably, confidently and on their own terms.

Informed by the Cog Model, our communication strategy takes hybrid complexity and flattens it into emotional simplicity. And not to get all B-school here, but that dual promise is what's called the Big Idea: "Go Beyond Range." What it means, to the consumer and to the people at the company, is technical excellence that unlocked emotional range. Living through a layered co-created creative ecosystem which tells the story of: a hero cinematic TVC, interactive microsite and co-created shortform influencer content.

The report includes category context, consumer tensions, strategic reframing, and creative rollout that collectively reflect how RAV4 is reinventing itself in the world of the shifting automobile.

Every touchpoint delivers more RAV4 edge: from the powerful front and sleek profile to the bold available wheels. It's more than just measurement—it's tracking emotional resonance, movement across behaviours, and a metaphorical language shift. With this campaign, Toyota doesn't simply roll out a car— it redefines what the RAV4 represents in human culture: not just a hybrid that functions, but a hybrid that feels right.

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# 1. Strategic Narrative & Cog Framework Overview

## 1.1 Introduction to Strategic Narrative

The strategic story for the arrival of the 2025 Toyota RAV4let™ is all about one thing: taking a vehicle that was trusted and rational and turning it into a desirable and emotional SUV. Since it was first launched in 1994, RAV4 has now come to represent “Resilient, Robust, and Reliable” as well as a car that’s designed for the great-outdoors and the great-indoors, for itself and for the world on its door-step that seeks endless adventure and to take that adventure even further, and as RAV4 approaches the era of its next generation, it reflects on that role and what it might contribute to its owner’s. But given the increasing sophistication of SUV buyers – particularly in the PHEV segment – there is a clear need for a new paradigm, one of which is not only performance, but also identity, lifestyle and aspiration as well.

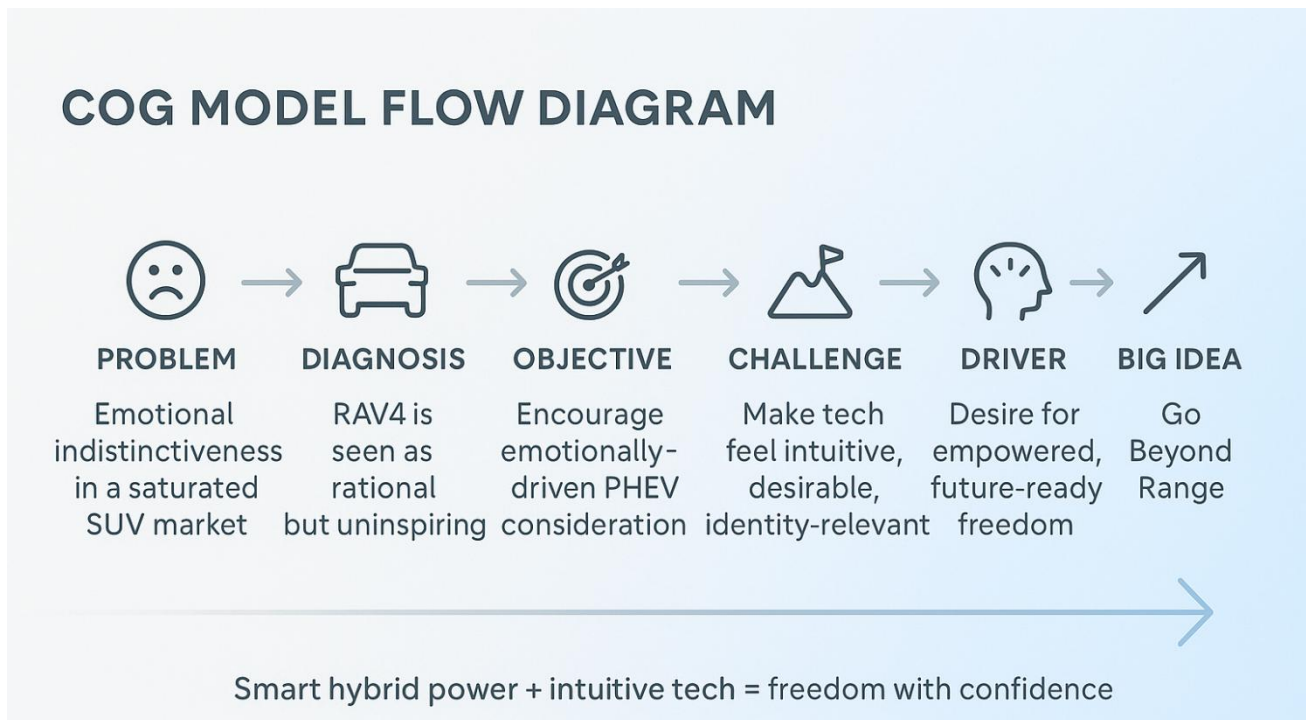
To make that shift emotional one, we need to get our head around and we need to influence what drives that underlying behaviour. Here is where the Cog Model is indispensable.

## 1.2 The Cog Model Framework

The Cog Model:

| Element           | Content                                                    |
|-------------------|------------------------------------------------------------|
| Problem           | Emotional indistinctiveness in a saturated SUV market      |
| Diagnosis         | RAV4 is seen as rational but uninspiring                   |
| Objective         | Encourage emotionally-driven PHEV consideration            |
| Cognitive Barrier | Hybrid tech seen as complex; RAV4 perceived as functional  |
| Challenge         | Make tech feel intuitive, desirable, and identity-relevant |
| Driver            | A desire for empowered, future-ready personal freedom      |

| Element       | Content                                                       |
|---------------|---------------------------------------------------------------|
| Big Idea      | “Go Beyond Range”                                             |
| Product Story | Smart hybrid power + intuitive tech = freedom with confidence |



## 2. Category and Problem Analysis

### 2.1 Category Landscape: From Utility to Emotion in the Electrified SUV Era

The Australian SUV category is undergoing a seismic shift. Once defined by utility, performance, and functional dependability, it is now shaped by electrification, environmental consciousness, and emotional identity. While SUV sales remain dominant (Warren, 2025), what consumers seek in an SUV has changed: they now want a vehicle that not only works but means something.

In this electrified era, RAV4’s historical strengths—reliability, hybrid efficiency, and practical utility—are no longer sufficient to drive desire. As plug-in hybrid electric vehicles (PHEVs) gain

regulatory and commercial traction, consumers are looking for brands that transform technical advancement into lifestyle empowerment. Function has become the entry point; emotion is now the differentiator.

Figure 1: The share of motor vehicle sales by segment, 2012 vs 2022.

Source: Author's analysis of VFACTS annual reports.

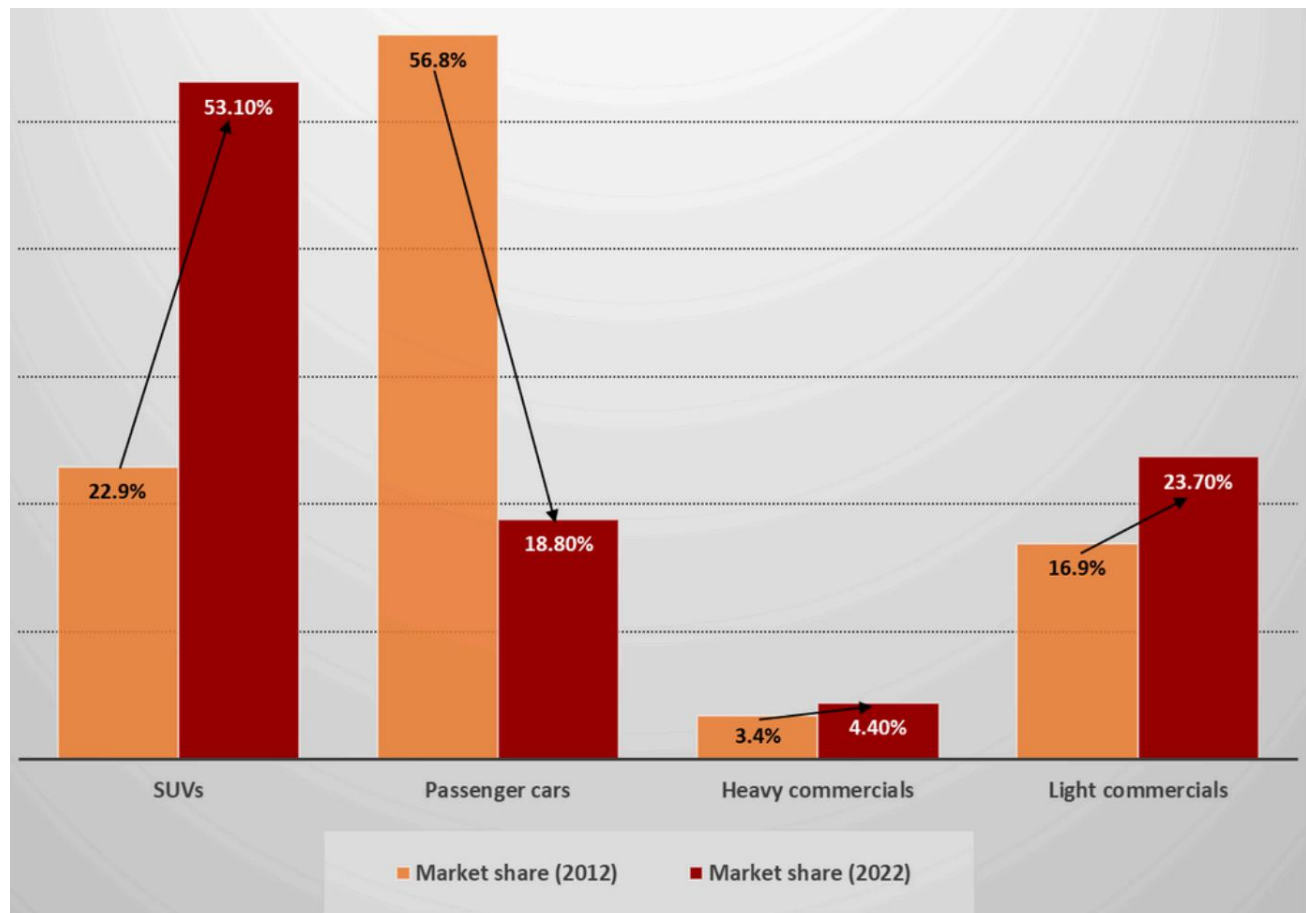


Table 1: A comparison of registered vehicle types by Australian state and territory, 2024.

Source: Author's analysis of Australian Automobile Association data, 2024

| State                        | ICE vehicles | Battery EVs | Plug-in Evs | % EVs 2024 | % EVs 2021 |
|------------------------------|--------------|-------------|-------------|------------|------------|
| New South Wales              | 5,464,456    | 49,768      | 161,980     | 3.73%      | 1.43%      |
| Victoria                     | 4,907,595    | 41,546      | 114,127     | 3.07%      | 1.10%      |
| Queensland                   | 4,148,122    | 34,495      | 95,697      | 3.14%      | 1.10%      |
| South Australia              | 1,424,754    | 7,624       | 33,841      | 2.91%      | 1.14%      |
| Western Australia            | 2,199,707    | 15,801      | 49,411      | 2.96%      | 1.02%      |
| Tasmania                     | 483,043      | 3,139       | 7,550       | 2.16%      | 0.77%      |
| Northern Territory           | 147,188      | 464         | 3,681       | 2.74%      | 0.93%      |
| Australian Capital Territory | 300,249      | 6,467       | 11,768      | 5.73%      | 2.20%      |

## 2.2 Competitive Landscape: How Rivals Win with Emotion

RAV4 faces two types of competitors, both of whom have advanced emotionally resonant storytelling:

- Traditional hybrids like the Mazda CX-5 position themselves not just through sleek design, but through the idea of “Jinba Ittai” (“horse and rider as one”)—a metaphor for harmony, control, and connection that transforms a drive into a relationship.

### JINBA ITTAI 人馬一体

Translating as **“horse and rider as one”**, *jinba-ittai* refers to the intuitive connection between a Mazda and its driver. It is the cornerstone on which Mazda’s designers and engineers base their work on. The phrase was first coined during the development of the MX-5 Miata but applies to every Mazda model. If you feel this oneness between yourself and your car, if it responds exactly as you intend, then you will experience a comfortable, safe and enjoyable drive.

(Mazda, 2017)

- New EV disruptors such as the BYD Atto 3 build appeal through a futurist aesthetic and immersive technology, positioning the car as a gateway to tomorrow’s lifestyle. Its cabin UI and sleek dashboard are not just features, but cues of personal progress.

These brands are not simply offering alternatives—they’re telling better stories.

In contrast, RAV4, while technologically credible, lacks a culturally or emotionally engaging narrative.

## **2.3 Strategic Problem Statement**

RAV4's legacy as "the smart choice" worked in a rational era. Today's SUV landscape, however, is shaped by emotion, image, and identity. Consumers want vehicles that reflect who they are—or who they aspire to become.

Thus, the central strategic problem emerges:

How can RAV4 shift from a "smart choice" to a "felt choice" ?

Addressing this requires tackling four intertwined challenges:

1. Elevating emotional resonance,
2. Differentiating in a crowded symbolic space,
3. Translating PHEV innovation into lifestyle benefits, and
4. Sustaining Toyota's leadership by redefining what leadership means in a meaning-driven category.

This category framing reveals not only where RAV4 stands, but what it must evolve into. To design a brand that emotionally connects, we must examine the emerging identity tensions and symbolic priorities shaping next-generation SUV buyers.

## **3. Consumer Understanding and Insight**

### **3.1 Segmentation and Target Persona: The New SUV Mindset**

In today's SUV market, consumers no longer choose based purely on function—they choose based on fit: how well a car aligns with who they are and who they want to become. Based on attitudinal and lifestyle segmentation (Choo & Mokhtarian, 2002), two key groups emerge:

- **Eco-Progressive Families (Sarah)**  
Value safety, reliability, and low emissions. They view hybrid vehicles as a responsible parenting choice. Typically research through Google, parenting blogs, and online review

aggregators before test-driving via dealerships.

- Urban Explorers (Leo, Main Focus)

Sustainability-minded professionals aged 30–45 who live in urban areas and seek independence, identity alignment, and minimal ecological footprint.

**Media Behaviour Tags:**

1. Follow sustainability influencers on Instagram and YouTube
2. Read EV forums, tech lifestyle platforms, and user-generated reviews
3. Trust brands that involve consumers in narrative co-creation rather than top-down messaging

**Persona Snapshot:**

| Attribute                   | Leo (Urban Explorers)                                                                                    | Sarah (Eco-Progressive Families)                                                                            |
|-----------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Age</b>                  | 34                                                                                                       | 38                                                                                                          |
| <b>Profession</b>           | Cloud Storage Operator (IT)                                                                              | Primary School Teacher                                                                                      |
| <b>Location</b>             | Inner Melbourne                                                                                          | Suburban Sydney                                                                                             |
| <b>Lifestyle</b>            | - Daily commute to work- Weekend nature escapes- Values sleek tech and social consciousness              | - Daily school runs- Nature-focused weekend plans- Values safety, sustainability, and practicality          |
| <b>Key Values</b>           | Clean technology, capability, individualism                                                              | Safety, sustainability, family-oriented responsibility                                                      |
| <b>Representative Quote</b> | <i>"I want a car that keeps up with my life and stands for something—clean, capable, not corporate."</i> | <i>"I'm not looking for the flashiest car—I want something safe, smart, and responsible for my family."</i> |

### 3.2 Customer Journey Mapping: Where Emotion Fails

Buyer journey reveals emotional drop-offs where RAV4 fails to meet symbolic needs:

| Journey Stage | Key Need                                  | Emotional Barrier                    | RAV4 Gap                       | Key Touchpoints (P/O/E)                                |
|---------------|-------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------|--------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------|
| Awareness     | Feel inspired by clean tech/stable future | Feels too rational, lacks excitement | Generic positioning            | <i>Instagram Ads (Paid), Earned mentions</i>           |
| Consideration | Understand emotional & green benefits     | Tech feels abstract or confusing     | Little lifestyle communication | <i>Toyota website (Owned), Reddit threads (Earned)</i> |
| Purchase      | Confidence in tech+identity fit           | Fears mismatch with self-image       | Few relatable user stories     | <i>Test-drive (Owned), YouTube vlogs (Earned)</i>      |
| Ownership     | Share and express the brand               | Not enough emotional reinforcement   | Weak social advocacy/community | <i>Instagram UGC (Earned), MyToyota App (Owned)</i>    |

### 3.3 Cognitive Barrier and Cultural Challenge

The key cognitive barrier is that:

Consumers perceive hybrid technology as a rational upgrade, not an emotional one.

For emotionally-driven buyers like Leo, the PHEV proposition sounds “smart” but feels cold and complex. As Rajagopal (2021) notes, “When consumers perceive a product as cognitively complex, they default to avoidance or delay—especially in emotionally-loaded categories like automotive purchases.”

This is amplified by Toyota’s brand tone: safe but uninspiring, technical but unsymbolic—failing to connect with today’s identity-led car culture.

### **3.4 Cognitive Driver: The Desire for Empowered Freedom**

Leo doesn't just want mobility—he wants alignment. He seeks confidence, purpose, and individuality, without compromising progress or aesthetics. PHEV can offer this, but only if the brand narrates it properly.

This is not about “being green” or “owning tech,” but about living with intention—and driving a vehicle that mirrors it. RAV4 must become a badge not just of performance, but of personal evolution.

*“Don't just go farther. Go further into who you want to be.”*

With this understanding, the creative platform must do more than inform—it must empower. It must reframe PHEV from a technical solution to a symbol of emotional progress. In the next section, we translate this into a brand story and product narrative that makes the leap from insight to identity.

## **4. Brand & Product Understanding**

### **4.1 Brand Legacy: From Rational Trust to Emotional Relevance**

Toyota's brand identity has long been anchored in QDR—Quality, Durability, Reliability; also it is a leader in the practical and family car segments. Historically, RAV4 has been perceived as the “smart” choice: safe, durable, efficient. Yet in a cultural landscape where SUVs are chosen not just for capability but for symbolic alignment, this rational trust must evolve into emotional relevance.

While competitors like Mazda embody design philosophy (“Jinba Ittai”), and BYD energises the category through futuristic storytelling, RAV4 risks being “the car you end up with,” not “the car that gets you.” Consumers trust Toyota—but they don't feel Toyota. This is the gap to close.

### **4.2 Repositioning Imperative: Emotionalise the Engineering**

Electrification, particularly in the PHEV form, demands more than technical credibility—it requires

emotional legitimacy. The new RAV4 must shift from being a machine for efficiency to a medium for meaning.

As Marc Gobé (2010) notes, emotional branding is about building shared values, not just communicating value. RAV4 must offer an experience that blends functional trust with personal aspiration—clean power, conscious living, confident control.

### **4.3 Product Story: Smart Hybrid Power, Emotionally Framed**

The new RAV4 PHEV offers substantial upgrades:

- >95km EV range for emission-free urban living
- 2.5L AWD-e hybrid system for empowered weekend escapes
- Over-the-air multimedia system for frictionless, connected experiences

But technical features alone do not move hearts. They must be re-coded:

- EV range isn't about fuel savings—it's about freedom from refuelling rituals.

AWD isn't about terrain—it's about owning the weekend with confidence.

Multimedia UX isn't about tech—it's about living in sync with your environment.

It's no longer just “what it does”—it's “what it enables you to become.”

#### **Core Value Proposition**

*“The SUV that thinks smart, feels free.”*

This captures the duality of RAV4's identity shift: from smart function to emotional freedom; from logic to lifestyle.

## **5. Big Idea & Strategic Platform**

### **5.1 From Insight to Idea: Reframing Freedom**

What we discovered was latent emotional tension: Consumers want to feel that they are in control of their lives and are aligned with progressive values — but current hybrid narratives are too rational, too dry and too far removed from personal meaning.

As Parker et al. (2021) stress that strong creative ideas are born of human truths, not product promises. What consumers are in search of isn't just more range — they're seeking more room to live intentionally, confidently, and freely.

## 5.2 The Big Idea

### “Go Beyond Range”

This concept works on two layers Read:

- EV range >95km is record miles with out petrol.
- Emotional: Go beyond the mechanical, the mundane, the corporate. Live life aligned with your values.

This Big Idea relieves the tension between what consumers think they want (EV specs) and what they really want (freedom and alignment). It transforms usefulness into meaning. It repositions RAV4 from a hybrid SUV to an emotional flatbed. It's not a question of what the car does; it's what it enables.

## 5.3 Strategic Platform: The Promise Canva

| Element         | Strategic Content                                                                 |
|-----------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Cause           | Consumers feel trapped by sameness, complexity, and lack of emotional connection. |
| Effect          | RAV4 PHEV offers a new kind of freedom—clean, capable, emotionally intelligent.   |
| Promise         | RAV4 lets you move through the world with power, ease, and identity alignment.    |
| Creative Role   | Turn invisible value (tech) into visible meaning (life moments).                  |
| Emotional Space | Calm confidence, future-readiness, personal agency, intuitive capability.         |

## 5.4 Archetype & Brand Voice

RAV4's new persona pulls from two archetypes:

Explorer – Desires freedom, development and new experiences

The Caregiving Friend – Safety, Assurance, Optionality

These types don’t just establish the tone — they also help “Go Beyond Range” communicate itself across platforms and yet, emotionally, stay the same. They are also the ones who lead voice and structure of storytelling, allowing for continuity without constraint.

And now, we go beyond theory — taking “Go Beyond Range,” the brand promise, from words to life via stories, technology, and moments. The next section shows how this Big Idea scales from media to interactions to time, transforming strategy into felt experience.

## 6. Creative Executions

### 6.1 Hero Execution: TVC – “Range of Life”

A cinematic hero film following three symbolic paths to emotional mobility. Each persona reflects a segment need and is mapped to a product feature.

| Persona                      | Need                            | Symbolic Scene                                                                                                               |
|------------------------------|---------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Urban Professional<br>(Leo)  | Seeks calm, tech,<br>minimalism | Glides silently through dawn-lit streets in EV mode                                                                          |
| Off-road Explorer            | Seeks autonomy, self-trust      | Powers through forest mud trails in AWD mode                                                                                 |
| Purposeful Parent<br>(Sarah) | Seeks stable and secure         | Stable and secure. Complete all household tasks (moving, picking up children, family self-driving tours), Hero in the family |

Tagline Close: “Go Beyond Range.”

Strategic Role: Drive emotional priming and recode product features into emotionally symbolic acts.

### 6.2 Hub Execution: Interactive Microsite – “What Drives You?”

Format: A personalised discovery hub that maps values to vehicle features.

Features:

- Lifestyle input → suggested RAV4 configurations
- EV range simulator with real-time destination matching
- Interactive “design your journey” avatar
- *New addition:*

Geo-targeted ‘Book a Test Drive’ module, bridging symbolic exploration with real-world action

**Strategic Role:** Educate, immerse, convert. From emotional association to experiential commitment.

### 6.3 Hygiene + Earned Execution: “Beyond the Map”

A co-created content series with real, values-led creators who live the Big Idea.

Format:

- 45–60s YouTube Shorts / Instagram Reels
- Episodic “micro-stories” like “My unplugged weekend” or “No range anxiety—just range clarity”

**Platform Rationale:**

- Instagram Reels and YouTube Shorts provide high-immersion, low-friction formats ideal for emotional storytelling under 60 seconds—perfect for our personas’s content habits.

**Strategic Role:** Build social proof and cultural presence beyond traditional media control.

### 6.4 Message Integration: Paid–Owned–Earned Ecosystem

| Funnel Stage         | Objective                   | Paid                        | Owned                                 | Earned                                |
|----------------------|-----------------------------|-----------------------------|---------------------------------------|---------------------------------------|
| <b>Awareness</b>     | Generate emotional salience | TVC, social teasers         | Toyota AU hero page                   | Creator Reels, lifestyle media pickup |
| <b>Consideration</b> | Deepen alignment & meaning  | Hub teaser campaign         | Microsite, blog content               | EV discussion forums, Reddit          |
| <b>Conversion</b>    | Drive test-drive action     | Targeted search/display ads | Test-drive tool, dealership scheduler | Organic reviews, customer UGC         |

Each channel role is designed to build memory structure and reduce emotional friction at moment of

decision (Sharp & Romaniuk, 2016).

These executions turn *Go Beyond Range* into a tangible reality. Each interaction nudges the consumer not with persuasion, but with self-recognition.

The next section details how we evaluate the campaign’s emotional, behavioural, and strategic effectiveness.

## 7. Measurement & Evaluation

### 7.1 Guiding Principle: Measuring Meaning, Not Just Metrics

The success of Go Beyond Range hinges not only on visibility, but on emotional imprinting and symbolic recoding. To evaluate this, we move beyond click metrics and apply a framework grounded in Ehrenberg-Bass thinking (Sharp & Romaniuk, 2016), measuring:

- Mental Availability – Are we top-of-mind at the PHEV moment?
- Emotional Coding – Do consumers feel emotionally aligned with RAV4?
- Behavioural Progression – Are digital signals translating to real-world action?

### 7.2 Multi-Stage Evaluation Framework

| Phase         | Strategic Focus           | Target Outcome                                       | Key Metrics (KPI)                                             | Tools & Methods                                    |
|---------------|---------------------------|------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------|
| Awareness     | Build emotional salience  | Consumers recall RAV4 in emotional SUV context       | Brand recall uplift, ad view-through rate, sentiment shift    | Brand tracker, YouTube analytics, social listening |
| Consideration | Reframe hybrid perception | Reassessment of hybrid from “rational” to “relevant” | Microsite dwell time, EV simulator completion, CTA engagement | GA4, heatmaps, UX analytics                        |
| Conversion    | Inspire real-world action | Test drive intent and dealership engagement          | Geo-targeted bookings, foot traffic, booking form conversion  | CRM attribution, Toyota dealer data                |

| Phase    | Strategic Focus              | Target Outcome                                  | Key Metrics (KPI)                                         | Tools & Methods                                    |
|----------|------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------|
| Advocacy | Build social proof & sharing | Increase in UGC and peer-to-peer brand language | UGC volume, organic SOV, share rate of influencer content | SproutSocial, TikTok/IG scrape, creator dashboards |

### 7.3 Evaluation Cadence: Real-Time Responsiveness

Evaluation will be conducted in fortnightly sprints during campaign rollout. This agile rhythm allows rapid testing and refinement of messaging, audience targeting, and creative tone—especially across earned and paid formats where emotional impact is most variable.

Each sprint review will be used to reweight media investment and update influencer briefs based on engagement quality and emotional trigger performance.

### 7.4 Cultural Impact Measurement: Language Shift as Signal

To assess whether Go Beyond Range is creating cultural and symbolic change, we track the evolution of user language:

- “This will be monitored through qualitative social scraping and NLP-based analysis of RAV4-related conversations across Reddit, product forums, and YouTube comments—measuring shifts in emotional descriptors (e.g., from ‘efficient’ to ‘empowering’, or ‘safe’ to ‘self-defining’).”

This data provides qualitative proof of brand re-coding—evidence that RAV4 is not just understood, but internalised and expressed. When consumers begin describing RAV4 with emotionally elevated language then the campaign has achieved more than reach. It has shifted brand meaning. We will know we’ve succeeded when drivers no longer say “it saves fuel”—but “it feels like me.”

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